Berlin. She opted to travel, holding off on a liver biopsy that may have prevented her journey to West Berlin. “I’m asymptomatic now except for a vicious gallbladder,” Lorde wrote in her journal. “And I can placate her. There are too many things I’m determined to do that I haven’t done yet.” She included on a short list of unfinished aims to “see what Europe’s all about.”[4]

Lorde’s early life and writerly output had previously inspired forms of identification across borders. She was born in 1934 after her parents had settled in New York City. She published poetry from her teen years onward and eventually worked as a professor to supplement her writing. In her early twenties, she visited Mexico, and international travel became a common mode and theme of her later work. Trips in the 1970s and early 1980s to Ghana, Barbados, the USSR, and Grenada greatly impacted her life and work, as did her activism on behalf of women writers of color and the antiapartheid movement in South Africa through the group she cofounded, SiSA (Sisterhood in Support of Sisters in South Africa).

Lorde’s first trip to divided Berlin in 1984 occurred in the midst of swirling turmoil but initiated a significant period of personal and communal transformation. She arrived in April and settled in an apartment on the ground floor of Auf dem Grat 26, outside the city center near the Free University in Dahlem. Lorde lived across from Thiel Park, a green space with meadows and a pond surrounded by willow trees. She explored the city with her partner Gloria Joseph, moving between circuits of mainstream and alternative cultural diplomacy. She led readings and discussions, including one at West Berlin’s Amerika Haus. She met with women in East Berlin.[5] At the Free University, Lorde taught three seminars: Contemporary Black Women’s Literature, Contemporary Black Women’s Poetry, and The Poet as Outsider.[6]

During her three-month stay, Lorde faced persistent health problems due to her ailing liver, including an inability to consume solid foods. Dagmar Schultz, the Free University instructor and women’s press editor who had invited the poet to West Berlin, found a homeopathic doctor who began treating Lorde’s cancer with injections of Iscador, a remedy derived from mistletoe. This form of therapy soothed her illness and energized her to write. By June 7, she had already written in her journal of the treatment, “I feel less weak,” and when she returned home later in the summer, she added, “Saints be praised! … The tumor has not grown, which means either the